

End of the Line for Manned Fighters?

While new superpowers China and India are steadily developing more sophisticated manned fighters of their own, in the West political pressure on costs has seen complete programs terminated and current fleets scheduled to continue for decades to come. Development of unmanned aircraft has continued; first used solely for surveillance, such aircraft are expected to fulfill wider roles in future conflicts, including air combat.

▷ BAe Harrier GR.9A 2003

Origin UK

Engine 23,800 lb (10,795 kg) thrust Rolls-Royce Pegasus 107 turbofan

Top speed 662 mph (1,065 km/h)

Fitted with the latest updated Pegasus engine and avionics and weapons upgrades, the final GR.9A version of BAe's class-leading vertical takeoff aircraft was retired in 2011 on cost grounds.

▽ Sukhoi Su-30 Mki 2000

Origin Russia

Engine 2 x 27,500 lb (12,474 kg) thrust Lyulka AL-31FP vectoring turbofan

Top speed 1,320 mph (2,124 km/h)

This high-performance Su-30 was developed jointly by Russia and India, which makes it for the Indian Air Force. It is highly agile thanks to its canard configuration and more than 150 have been built.



▷ Lockheed Martin Boeing F-22 Raptor 2005

Origin US

Engine 2 x 23,500-35,000 lb (10,659-15,876 kg) thrust Pratt & Whitney F119-PW-100 Pitch Thrust vectoring turbofan

Top speed 1,669 mph (2,686 km/h)

Hugely expensive but claimed to be the best fighter in the world, the F-22 combines stealth technology with fighter, ground attack, electronic warfare, and signals intelligence capabilities; 195 were built.



△ Boeing F/A-18E Super Hornet 2000

Origin US

Engine 2 x 13,000-22,000 lb (5,896-9,979 kg) thrust General Electric F414-GE-400 afterburning turbofan

Top speed 1,190 mph (1,915 km/h)

With 50 percent greater endurance, the larger, more powerful version of the Hornet had long been planned. It finally entered service in 2000 with the US Navy and in 2010 with the Australian Air Force.



△ Eurofighter Typhoon FGR4 2007

Origin UK, Germany, Italy, Spain

Engine 2 x 20,000 lb (9,060 kg) thrust EJ200 turbofan

Top speed 1,538 mph (2,475 km/h)

The FGR4—Fighter, Ground attack, and Reconnaissance, Mk4—was introduced in 2007 when the RAF's Typhoon fighters were upgraded to these two new roles. Some were modified and some newly built.

Unmanned Aircraft

Are Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs), or “drones,” the future of aerial warfare? Will they slug it out in dogfights, dash to rescue lost troops, or shoot down enemy bombers? Their use for observation started in the 1990s with the Predator, and, as technology has advanced, some can now carry—and fire—missiles for attack or defense. It is possible for troops and supplies to be carried to the front line in craft flown only by computers. However, there is still a long way to go before the fighter ace is relegated to the history books.



△ Selex Galileo Falco Evo 2012

Origin Italy

Engine 80 hp UAV petrol, possibly flat-6

Top speed 134 mph (216 km/h)

This compact and light Unmanned Aerial Vehicle was built for Pakistan. In original form, it was only capable of medium-altitude surveillance duties, but the Evo is expected to carry weapons, too.